RONALD REAGAN

An American Life



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Haig made great good sense on this entire matter. It's amazing how sound he can be on complex international matters but how utterly paranoid with regard to the people he must work with."

I first met Al Haig in the 1970s when he was commander of NATO, and I was greatly struck with him at that time. He was highly respected as the military leader of the Atlantic alliance, and that was why he was my first choice as secretary of state. But the Al Haig who was my secretary of state wasn't the same Al Haig I met when he was at NATO. He was effective in getting our new policy of realism and peace through strength off the ground, but we sometimes disagreed on other things. He never said as much to me, but others told me he had shocked some congressmen by giving them the impression that if it were up to him, he'd deal with some of our problems in Central America and Cuba with a bombing run or an invasion. He and I also differed about Taiwan: I regarded Taiwan as a loyal, democratic, longtime ally to whom we owed unqualified support. Haig and others at the State Department were so eager to improve relations with the People's Republic of China that they pressed me to back away from this pledge of support. I felt we had an obligation to the people of Taiwan, and no one was going to keep us from meeting it.

During that first year, Haig threatened several times to quit, but I talked him out of it. In June of 1982, as the Falklands crisis was coming to an end, he issued the same threat to senior members of the White House staff, claiming they were invading his turf. When he came to the Oval Office the next day, I was prepared to accept his resignation, but he didn't resign; instead, he launched into a bitter attack on the top staff and gave me a bill of particulars listing his complaints, which he asked me to correct. In fact, a few of his grievances were legitimate: One or more people in the White House were trying to do him in with malicious leaks to the press. Still, the jealousies and turf battles had gone too far. Two days later, apparently after he had decided I wasn't going to respond to his demands, he came to my office again, and this time submitted his resignation. I think he was hoping I would not accept it. But when I did, he didn't seem surprised. I had asked the staff to sound out George Shultz about becoming secretary of state; I called him and he accepted.

"This has been a heavy load," I wrote in my diary June 25.

tunnels under the demilitarized buffer zone between the two Koreas, I said.

That night, there was another twelve-course dinner; somehow, the second one went down easier than the first had. By then, I guess I was really heeding Dick Nixon's advice.

The following day was the big event of the trip, my meeting with the top man in China, Chairman Deng Xiaoping. A small man with thick shoulders and dark, impressive eyes, Deng exhibited a playful sense of humor when we met. Nancy had come with me for the formal introduction, and Deng smilingly asked her to come back to China without me someday so he could show it to her. But later, when we got down to business, his smile was gone and he immediately began criticizing the United States for a whole range of supposed sins: our support of Israel, which he claimed made the entire Middle East unstable; our treatment of the developing nations; and our failure to come to terms on a nuclear arms agreement with the Soviets.

As host, he got the first shot. Then it was my turn. I did my best to rebut just about everything he'd said, correcting his facts and figures. Host or not, he'd touched a nerve, so I let him have it. After that, to my surprise, he suddenly started to warm up; his smile came back and he seemed to want to relax and be more cordial. Still, that didn't keep him from bringing up our friendship with Taiwan, which he claimed was an interference with Chinese affairs. I told him that the split between the PRC and Taiwan was a problem to be worked out by the Chinese, but that the United States wanted it worked out peacefully; any attempt at a military solution mounted by his country would damage relations between our countries beyond repair.

By the time we broke for lunch, the intensity of our earlier discussion had faded into a warm and pleasant social event with toasts all around. By then, I think I understood him, and he understood me. After lunch, I picked up Nancy and we left for a visit to the Great Wall, with huge crowds waving to us along the way. Although I'd seen photographs of the Great Wall since childhood, seeing it rise up and disappear over the mountains in both directions was a tremendously emotional experience, one that even now I have trouble fully describing.

During our tour of Beijing, it seemed that everywhere we looked